against Kuki-Zos. He calls it doctored, and the Supreme Court is examining its authenticity. That left the gap for a Khemchand-like figure.

PARALLELS DON'T MEET

Like Biren, Khemchand began in the Democratic Revolutionary People's Party, the fruit of a Meitei stir against a lingering 1997 ceasefire with the Naga insurgent group NSCN(IM). Biren became an MLA in 2002, eventually merging the party with the Congress. Khemchand waited, honing his skills in sports administration. After a failed electoral bid as a Trinamool candidate in 2012, he joined the BJP in 2013, won from Singjamei in 2017, and served as Speaker till 2022. Re-elected that year, he became a minister.

In late 2023, during the violence, his home was attacked with a grenade. That's when he joined the dissidents. In 2024, he publicly urged Biren to resign. Days later, armed men gathered outside his residence and security had to step in. His was a key voice leading up to Biren's February 2025 resignation: days before that, Khemchand was in Delhi, warning that disgruntled BJP MLAs might back a Congress no-confidence motion, risking the government's collapse.

A DIFFICULT PEACE

Now he has the chance to chart a new path. Nemcha's elevation signals his regime is not hostile to the Kuki-Zo or to dialogue. But with two major bodies in Kuki Impi and Kuki Zo Council asking co-ethnic MLAs to stay away from a 'Meitei-centric' arrangement, reconciliation is easier declared than achieved. One stark fact showed the scale of mistrust: Nemcha had to take her oath virtually because Imphal could not guarantee her safety.

Restoring a semblance of normalcy in Manipur calls for many urgent steps, most of all the resettlement of displaced people. But real peace lies beyond deep fault lines. The core Kuki-Zo demand evokes something non-negotiable for the Meiteis too: territorial division, as always, is an existential question. ■



▶ MAHARASHTRA

A HEAVY MANTLE OF RESPONSIBILITY

The plan for a political reunion of the Pawar clan ends with Ajit. Wife Sunetra, sworn in as deputy CM, maps an independent future for her NCP

By **Dhaval S. Kulkarni**

TWO LINES ON A MESSY POLITICAL map were about to converge when they hit an air pocket on the foggy morning of January 28—as a Learjet, carrying deputy chief minister Ajit Pawar (66), missed the tabletop airstrip in his native Baramati and crashed in an open field. But shock and grief soon fragmented into more complex emotions for the Pawar family. For, the air of tragedy took no time to be pierced by some sharp realpolitik.

A powerful caucus in Ajit's party had moved in swiftly, giving Maharashtra a new deputy CM: Ajit's widow Sunetra. Sombre, sheathed in a white shawl, the 62-year-old took her oath on January 31. A step-sister of political veteran Padamsinh Bajirao Patil, and married to one of the state's most dynamic leaders for 41 years, she has had a long ringside view of the game but now faces a challenging task in only her second year in formal politics.

Especially because it was a pre-emptive coup of sorts. What it did is stall a reunion of the Nationalist Congress Party (NCP), undoing Ajit's final moves. After a bitter estrangement of over two years, Ajit and his uncle, former Union minister Sharad Pawar, were poised to shake hands. That prospective event would have shifted the state's very tectonic plates and resonated much further afield. After all, an Opposition stalwart would have entered the BJP's axis of influence, dealing a body blow to the Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA) and denting the morale of the INDIA bloc nationally.

But there was a narrower set of implications that didn't suit a set of satraps. In the vacuum after Ajit's